Asad Ikram

MSc Data Analytics (Distinction), University of Portsmouth · Chevening Scholar 2024/25
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PROFILE

Social media researcher and data engineer working on online political opinion: how people express it on platforms, and when machine-labelled measures of it can be compared across platforms and languages. Eight years of collecting and analysing large multilingual text, LLM labelling and fine-tuned classifiers in production, and a methods paper on cross-platform measurement. I want to study how elite communication, voter engagement and algorithms drive affective polarisation.

ELIGIBILITY FOR THIRD-CYCLE STUDIES IN POLITICAL SCIENCE

General requirements	Second-cycle degree: MSc Data Analytics, University of Portsmouth (Distinction, 2025), 90 ECTS (180 UK credits) at second-cycle level. First-cycle: BS Computer Science, FAST-NUCES (130 credit hours).
Independent thesis	30 ECTS (60 UK credits), examined and graded 78/100: *Cross-Platform Sentiment Analysis of Public Reaction to UK Economic Policies*, public opinion on government policy (taxation, welfare, inflation, stimulus) measured with automated text analysis. Submitted for assessment as equivalent in relation to the project.
Knowledge of the field	Research on public opinion and policy (thesis; arXiv:2610.16757, which adapts survey methodology to social media measurement); applied social media analysis for UK government communications teams.

ASSESSMENT CRITERIA

Research on the project's themes	Public reaction to policy on four platforms (thesis); cross-platform measurement of machine-labelled opinion (paper with Dr Ella Haig); twelve-month discourse study of 270,000+ mentions (Fluency).
Automated text analysis	Fine-tuned BERT, XLM-R, DistilBERT, DeBERTa; LLM labelling chain (Claude, DeepSeek) checked against hand-labelled posts; toxicity and hostility classifiers, storm detection and banter filters (Artemis AI).
Programming, large-scale data	Python and SQL daily; 500+ collectors across 15 markets (Dubizzle Labs); ten platforms daily (Fluency); 3 million+ comments processed (Artemis AI).
Languages	English (working language; MSc taught and assessed in English), Urdu (native); text pipelines in Arabic and Hindi. No Swedish or Finnish yet; would begin Swedish courses in the first term.

RESEARCH

Ikram, A. and Haig, E. "Is the Platform Part of the Measurement? A Protocol and Simulation Study for Cross-Platform Equivalence of Machine-Labelled Policy Sentiment." Preprint, arXiv:2610.16757 (2026), arxiv.org/abs/2610.16757. Treats each platform as a survey mode and applies generalizability theory, measurement invariance and differential item functioning, and score linking to machine-labelled text. I built the simulation: with known ground truth, pooling platform scores at face value gives the wrong sign of daily aggregate sentiment on roughly a quarter of days, from measurement differences alone. *No peer-reviewed publications to date.*

EDUCATION

Sep 2024 - Sep 2025
awarded 8 Dec 2025

MSc Data Analytics, Distinction. University of Portsmouth, United Kingdom. Chevening Scholar. Credit-weighted average 70.5/100; master's project 78/100. Supervisor: Dr Ella Haig. Modules included Big Data and Machine Learning, Intelligent Data and Text Analytics, Explainable AI and Data Management.

Dissertation: *Cross-Platform Sentiment Analysis of Public Reaction to UK Economic Policies*. About 279,000 public posts from X/Twitter, Reddit, YouTube and Quora, under university ethics approval (TETHIC-2025-111094). Fine-tuned BERT against BiLSTM and lexicon baselines; 200 posts hand-labelled; McNemar and bootstrap tests, chi-square tests across topics, Prophet forecasting.

Aug 2017 - Jan 2022

BS Computer Science. National University of Computer and Emerging Sciences (FAST-NUCES), Pakistan.
Courses included Probability and Statistics, Linear Algebra, Calculus I and II, Numerical Methods, Design and Analysis of Algorithms, Database Systems and Applied Machine Learning.

EXPERIENCE

Dec 2024 - present
part-time, remote

Data Engineer, M+C Saatchi Fluency, London. Social media analysis for global brands including Amazon, Ford, Nike and Reckitt, and for UK government.

- Analyst on a twelve-month discourse study (100,845 Brandwatch and 170,542 Reddit mentions): BERTopic-derived codebook, LLM tagging with a prompt-version hash on every tag, three pilot runs on the same 500 rows before the full run.
- Social data collection, labelling and tagging, text and sentiment analysis with AI/ML, forum sourcing and pipeline architecture; a weekly pipeline of 2.2 million rows.

- Built a self-healing agent that diagnoses a broken forum crawler, regenerates it and tests it on live pages, and a builder agent that creates new crawlers, across a fleet of 64; secured with prompt fencing and approval gates, and I approve each merge.

2025 - present part-time

Co-Founder and Chief Technology Officer, Artemis AI, United Kingdom. Social-media intelligence for creators and businesses.

- Processed 3 million+ Facebook and Instagram comments (111,000+ posts) on AWS: Meta Graph API collectors, an Apache Iceberg warehouse, and an LLM labelling cascade designed to escalate from our own NLP models to DeepSeek and then Claude.
- Building a 48-model system for the 15 December 2026 beta: comment toxicity, intent and topic classifiers tested on blind human-labelled sets; a storm detector for bursts of hostile comments; spam, bot, language and banter filters so dialect is not read as toxicity; community detection and match scoring on the network of pages; best-time, engagement-outlook and post-health models; image and video understanding (OCR, CLIP, Whisper); and Art-E, a retrieval-based advisor on Amazon Bedrock.
- Designed the LLM labelling chain: Claude labels about 6,000 posts with an explanation each, rules mined from the explanations prompt DeepSeek, and its labels train our own encoder classifiers; evaluation built around a human-labelled golden set.
- Lead a team of five across models, AI/ML, deployment, app development and design; take part in pitching.

Feb 2022 - Aug 2024 full-time

Associate Software Engineer, then Data Engineer, then Senior Data Engineer, Dubizzle Labs (Dubizzle, Bayut, Zameen, OLX), Lahore. Promoted twice in about two and a half years.

- Data modelling and machine learning for competitor-intelligence dashboards: what people discussed, how much volume each site carried, and what worked on each platform and in which region.
- Designed the company's first web-scraping architecture on AWS: 15 markets, English, Arabic, Urdu and Hindi; led a team of three engineers in scraping and data warehousing. Owned a data-warehousing product end to end.

May 2023 - present contract, remote

Data Engineer (contract), Fix.com, Canada. OCR-based machine learning to parse parts catalogues from PDFs; models to backfill missing parts data; since June 2026, sole designer and operator of the crawler platform (about 10 million rows across 82 datasets).

2018 - 2026 remote

Other data engineering work. Lead Data Engineer, VendueTech, Ireland (2025: Azure-to-AWS migration, team of three); Data Engineer, Prefe, Milan (2024); CXG, Dubai (production crawlers, pytest QA); Metoda, Germany; web-scraping architecture for a US start-up and businesses in the Netherlands and Lithuania; earlier work for companies in India and Japan; freelance on Fiverr from 2018, starting during my BS: 300+ clients.

SKILLS

Coding	Python (pandas, Scrapy, PyTorch, FastAPI, pytest), SQL, PySpark; Git, GitHub and CI.
Data and databases	Collection from APIs and the open web at scale; cleaning, deduplication, joins and validation; PostgreSQL, Redshift, Athena, DynamoDB, Apache Iceberg; AWS, Docker, Kubernetes.
Modelling and statistics	Hypothesis tests (McNemar, chi-square), bootstrap, Prophet forecasting; simulation with known ground truth; generalizability theory, measurement invariance and DIF, score linking; validating machine and LLM labels against human-labelled sets.
NLP and AI	Fine-tuning encoder classifiers (BERT, XLM-R, DistilBERT, DeBERTa-v3); LLM-assisted labelling (Claude, DeepSeek); OCR, CLIP and Whisper; BERTopic; LIME and integrated gradients; building AI agents; AI coding assistants (Claude Code, OpenAI Codex), where I write the specification and tests and decide what merges.

AWARDS, COMMUNITY AND LANGUAGES

Chevening	Chevening Scholar 2024/25 (UK Government's global scholarship, which funded the MSc), awarded for helping students and junior colleagues into freelance and remote careers and for a proposed cross-platform social media analytics system to give government evidence of public opinion.
Community	Author and maintainer of web-scraping-guide.com (since May 2026), a free public guide to web data collection. Helped university students start freelance careers and junior colleagues at Dubizzle into remote work; two of them got remote jobs.
Languages	Urdu (native); English (working language; MSc taught and assessed in English, IELTS 6.5).

REFEREES

Dr Ella Haig, Associate Professor in AI, School of Computing, University of Portsmouth. Ella.Haig@port.ac.uk. MSc dissertation supervisor and co-author.

Dr Fahad Ahmad, Senior Lecturer, Centre for Cybercrime and Economic Crime, University of Portsmouth. Fahad.Ahmad@port.ac.uk. Taught and assessed me on the MSc.